

ASSERTING THE INTELLECT OVER EMOTIONS

2018

Context: This essay concerns ordinary emotional states in a psychologically healthy adult. It is not about trauma responses, PTSD triggers, or clinical mood disorders, and it should not be applied to situations involving a risk of self-harm or depressive/manic episodes. Those are qualitatively different phenomena and require a different approach.

How many times have you heard the statement:

"You can't choose who you fall in love with."

Love, trust, and many other emotional states are not simply *on* or *off*. Each has a variable degree to which the emotion is felt. The real question is: *Who decides the intensity?*

No one else can force you to act, choose, or commit. Emotions may arise on their own, but you *can* choose what you do with them once they arise. And you can choose the degree to which you indulge them, rehearse them, intensify them, or obey them.

But the real question here is: “*Do emotions or the intellect determine behavior?*”

The answer for most people is: “A little from column A and a little from column B,” without being in control of when or in which situations they may get one or the other. The thesis of this essay is that you can choose and you should choose the intellect in all but a few instances. But the point is that you have control over exactly which instances you prefer for the emotional center to take control (e.g. making love).

There’s a fundamental problem we’re up against here: Emotions register in the brain almost instantaneously, yet your intellect takes several seconds before it can render a verdict. So, there’s literally a timing issue. There are two solutions to this problem:

1. Training a response through repetitive practice. That way, the intellect doesn’t have to reason through the evidence to reach a conclusion because the response in this situation has been predetermined, so the desired action can begin almost instantly. This is how police, soldiers, and emergency medical personnel are able to react quickly in life-or-death situations.
2. Predict that a thing is likely to happen based on circumstantial clues and begin planning your response in advance. The advantage here is that it doesn’t require spending time rehearsing responses. The downside is that it requires acute situational awareness that in itself requires training to develop.

If you are feeding emotions that are disproportionate or inappropriate for the circumstances, *stop feeding them*. The normal cycle time for experiencing an emotion is 90 seconds.⁶⁴ However, if you allow the intellect to engage with the emotion or begin to rationalize the emotion, the experience can last much longer.

Now that we have a handle on the situation from a theoretical perspective, let's dive into a method to actually put this into practice.

STEP ONE

Asserting the dominance of the intellect over the emotions (i.e. "*love under will*") is a *diminishing skill*. Therefore, it must be deliberately *trained*.

The only way to master emotions is to master the ability to *exert the intellect over them*. This begins with a simple practice: every time an emotion arises in you - seemingly on its own, or in response to something - pause and examine it.

Ask:

- Why did this emotion emerge?
- Why *this* emotion?
- Why at this intensity?

If your emotional response agrees with what your intellect says it should have been, good. But don't stop there; we're building *muscle memory*.

And if the emotion is inappropriate, excessive, or outside the limits you're choosing to maintain, *interrupt the escalation loop*. Deprive it of oxygen. Withdraw attention. Redirect focus. Restore command of the

⁶⁴ Taylor, Dr. Jill Bolte, "*My Stroke of Insight*", Penguin Books, 2009

temple.

Yes, you can do it.

And with enough practice, you can even reprogram old conditioned reflexes. The trick isn't suppression; it's training a new automatic response: one that invokes the intellect instead of locking it out.

STEP TWO

Most of your responses to outside stimuli are scripted based on past behavior (habits), not consciously crafted in real time. That's your brain taking shortcuts so it can respond quickly in situations with too many variables to analyze on the spot.

This is why people often behave absurdly in high-stress moments. Watch footage of an active shooter in a public place: many people *freeze* where they stand. It's one of the worst possible reactions because it makes you the easiest possible target. And they do it not because they're stupid, but because the automatic response to a loud unknown noise is to stop, become silent, and listen to determine whether the noise truly indicates a threat or not.

That works when your car makes a strange noise. It works far less well in a gun fight.

But it gets worse: Sometimes, the event is so dramatic that the brain rejects it as being so improbable that it stalls in disbelief. By the 3rd or 4th shot the mind typically re-engages and resumes processing normally. But until then, you remain trapped in the default script.

Circling back to the original premise, the dating world may be

dramatic, but it isn't a gun fight. Still, the process is the same. If you're reacting inappropriately or disproportionately, part of the reason may be that your mind has no refined script for this kind of situation, especially if the emotional scenario is rare, new, or destabilizing.

This is especially common in situations where a person is performing based on a script or a set of advice rather than showing up authentically. In such a case, one of two things are very likely to happen:

1. Something occurs that causes the situation to move into an area the script did not cover.
2. The person fears that the situation may move into an area that the script does not cover.

In either case, the result will be stress and unpredictable behavior. The solution is to do what everyone has been telling you to do since the beginning: "Just be yourself."⁶⁵ This method doesn't yield the highest chance of the person being attracted to you. But unless your goal is exploitation, what's the point of inducing someone to be attracted to a person who doesn't really exist?

Self-awareness is not only a matter of being aware of what you're doing and how you are likely to be perceived by others, it's also about remembering who you are and making sure that your speech and behaviors are aligned with that truth. Combine that with trained intellectual dominance and you will very quickly begin to see your reactions as something you have control over rather than something you must obey.

STEP THREE

⁶⁵ And stop worrying about how other people perceive you.

None of us perceives anything close to objective reality.⁶⁶ Most of what we respond to is not *the person*, but our internal image of the person. That image is comprised of fragmentary observation, assumption, projection, and symbol.

Yes, other people can influence that image. Some can even craft it deliberately. But we're focused on authenticity.

In general, we must accept that we will never grasp the full truth of anything. Our reality is largely subconscious projection onto the faintest glimmer of truth: "*as above, so below.*"

Knowing that, the best we can do is ensure that our personal image is as close to truth as possible.

And truth has a location: *The present.*

Your only real point of reference is what is happening now. Therefore, if you want to perceive accurately, you must ruthlessly purge your mind of thoughts that are not in the present.

For example:

- How your last partner wronged you is not in the present.
- The way this person reminds you of someone else is not in the present.
- What this person might do in the future is obviously not in the present.
- Even the imagined "nature and duration" of this relationship is not in the present.

⁶⁶ Assuming that objective reality even exists.

Clear away the noise and you'll suddenly have the mental capacity to detect the actual nuances of your condition:

What is real

What is happening

What is being asked of you.

That information will serve you far better than *fear, fantasy*, or reflexive *scripting* ever will.

This is the basic idea behind *Living Consciously*. Using these tools, anyone can begin to master themselves and their environment.